Tallihaus

# The House Binder

Everything about your home in one place: where the shutoffs are, what's installed, when it was serviced and who did the work.

PHOTO OF YOUR HOME

ADDRESS

OWNERS

MOVED IN

IF FOUND, PLEASE CALL

Tallihaus

A CLOSING GIFT

# Welcome home.

This binder is for everything about your new home: where the shutoffs are, what's installed, when it was serviced and who did the work. Start with the emergency pages, then fill in the rest as things come up.

**With thanks from**

## Track all of this on your phone, free

The Tallihaus app keeps your upkeep checklist, reminders, appliances, bills and mortgage in one place. Scan to get it.

# How to use this binder

You don't need to fill it all in at once. Start with the emergency pages, then add the rest as things come up.

## A few tips

- [ ] **Do the emergency pages first.** Find the water shutoff and map the breaker panel before you need them, not during a leak.
- [ ] **Take photos of labels.** Model and serial numbers are on a sticker on each appliance. A photo is faster than copying them.
- [ ] **Print more of the pages you use most.** The logs, appliance pages and inventory are made to be printed again.
- [ ] **Keep it where anyone can find it.** A kitchen shelf or near the breaker panel. Tell the people you live with where it is.
- [ ] **Don't write passwords or full account numbers.** The last four digits are enough to find an account.
- [ ] **Selling someday?** Buyers love getting the systems, maintenance and paint pages. Keep the money pages for yourself.

## What's inside

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# Your first month

The things worth doing right after you move in, roughly in order. Write the date when each one is done.

## First day

- [ ] **Change the locks and garage codes** — DATE
  Past owners, agents and contractors may still have keys.
- [ ] **Find the water shutoff and breaker panel** — DATE
  Mark them on the Shutoffs and safety page.
- [ ] **Test smoke and CO alarms** — DATE
- [ ] **Photograph the meters** — DATE
  Your starting readings, in case a first bill looks wrong.
- [ ] **Photograph every room before you unpack** — DATE
  A record of the shape the house was in when you got it.

## First week

- [ ] **Replace the furnace filter** — DATE
  Write the size on the Sizes and spare parts page.
- [ ] **Set the water heater to about 120°F** — DATE
  Hot enough for most homes, and lowers the risk of scalding.
- [ ] **Map the breaker panel and fill in the emergency contacts** — DATE
- [ ] **Put a fire extinguisher in the kitchen** — DATE
- [ ] **Clean the dryer vent** — DATE
  You don't know when it was last done.
- [ ] **Learn trash and recycling days** — DATE

## First month

- [ ] **Ask your county about a homestead or owner tax break** — DATE
  Many have a sign-up deadline.
- [ ] **Note your first mortgage payment date** — DATE
  It's usually a month or two after closing. Don't miss it.
- [ ] **Change your address everywhere** — DATE
  Driver's license, voter registration, bank, insurance, employer.
- [ ] **Book furnace and AC service if there are no records** — DATE
- [ ] **Find the appliance manuals** — DATE
  Search the model number online for a free PDF.
- [ ] **Find out how old everything is** — DATE
  The How old is it? page shows how to read the label.
- [ ] **Keep your closing papers in one safe place** — DATE

# Your home at a glance

Most of this is on your listing, inspection report or county property record.

| YEAR BUILT | SQUARE FEET | LOT SIZE | STORIES |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |

| BEDROOMS | BATHROOMS | GARAGE | PARCEL NUMBER |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |

## How it's built

FOUNDATION

☐ Full basement ☐ Crawl space ☐ Slab

BASEMENT

☐ Finished ☐ Unfinished ☐ Partly ☐ None

ROOF TYPE AND COLOR

SIDING

WINDOWS

FLOORING

## How it runs

HEAT

☐ Gas furnace ☐ Heat pump ☐ Electric ☐ Boiler
☐ Oil / propane

COOLING

☐ Central AC ☐ Heat pump ☐ Window units
☐ None

WATER

☐ City ☐ Well

SEWER

☐ City ☐ Septic

WATER HEATER

☐ Gas tank ☐ Electric tank ☐ Tankless
☐ Heat pump

ELECTRICAL SERVICE

☐ 100 amp ☐ 150 amp ☐ 200 amp ☐ Other

## Good to know about this house

Quirks, tricks and things the last owner told you

# Key numbers

Who to call about the house itself. Write only the last four digits of account and loan numbers.

## Mortgage

LENDER OR LOAN SERVICER

LOAN NUMBER (LAST 4)

PHONE

MONTHLY PAYMENT

DUE DAY

INTEREST RATE

PAID OFF IN (YEAR)

TAXES AND INSURANCE IN ESCROW?

☐ Yes ☐ No

## Homeowners insurance

COMPANY

POLICY NUMBER (LAST 4)

AGENT AND PHONE

CLAIMS PHONE

RENEWS ON

DEDUCTIBLE

FLOOD INSURANCE?

☐ Yes ☐ No

SEWER BACKUP COVERAGE?

☐ Yes ☐ No

## Property tax

COUNTY

YEARLY TAX

DUE DATES

WHERE TO PAY OR APPEAL

HOMESTEAD OR OTHER TAX BREAK FILED?

☐ Yes ☐ No

## HOA

If you have one

NAME AND MANAGER

PHONE

DUES

DUE

PORTAL OR WEBSITE

## When you bought

PURCHASE PRICE

CLOSING DATE

TITLE COMPANY

# Paint and finishes

For touch-ups and matching later. The color code is on the lid of the can.

| Room | Wall color and brand | Code | Sheen | Trim and ceiling | Flooring |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Living room | | | | | |
| Kitchen | | | | | |
| Dining room | | | | | |
| Primary bedroom | | | | | |
| Bedroom | | | | | |
| Bedroom | | | | | |
| Bathroom | | | | | |
| Bathroom | | | | | |
| Hallways and stairs | | | | | |
| Basement | | | | | |
| Laundry | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| OUTSIDE | | | | | |
| Siding | | | | | |
| Trim | | | | | |
| Front door | | | | | |
| Deck or fence stain | | | | | |

## Other finishes

COUNTERTOPS

CABINETS

CABINET HARDWARE

TILE AND GROUT COLOR

CAULK COLOR

LIGHT BULBS (TYPE, COLOR)

**Tip:** Keep a small labeled jar of each paint color. Cans that freeze in a garage can go bad.

# Shutoffs and safety

Walk the house once and find each of these. Tape a photo in the box, or draw a quick arrow.

### Main water shutoff

WHERE

TURN WHICH WAY

PHOTO

### Gas shutoff

WHERE

TOOL NEEDED

PHOTO

### Electrical panel

WHERE

MAIN BREAKER SIZE

PHOTO

### Water heater

WHERE

SHUTOFF VALVE

PHOTO

### Sump pump

WHERE

BACKUP OR ALARM?

PHOTO

### Outdoor faucet shutoffs

WHERE

HOW MANY

PHOTO

### Fire extinguishers

WHERE

EXPIRES

PHOTO

### Smoke and CO alarms

WHERE

REPLACE BY (DATE ON BACK)

PHOTO

**If you smell gas, leave first**

Get everyone out, then call the gas company or 911 from outside. Shut the gas off only if it's safe and you know how. Only the gas company should turn it back on.

# Breaker panel map

Flip one breaker at a time while someone calls out what went dark. Most panels number odd on the left and even on the right.

PANEL LOCATION _____ PANEL BRAND _____ MAIN BREAKER (AMPS) _____

| # | Amps | What it controls | # | Amps | What it controls |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | 2 | | |
| 3 | | | 4 | | |
| 5 | | | 6 | | |
| 7 | | | 8 | | |
| 9 | | | 10 | | |
| 11 | | | 12 | | |
| 13 | | | 14 | | |
| 15 | | | 16 | | |
| 17 | | | 18 | | |
| 19 | | | 20 | | |
| 21 | | | 22 | | |
| 23 | | | 24 | | |
| 25 | | | 26 | | |
| 27 | | | 28 | | |
| 29 | | | 30 | | |
| 31 | | | 32 | | |
| 33 | | | 34 | | |
| 35 | | | 36 | | |
| 37 | | | 38 | | |
| 39 | | | 40 | | |

**Tip:** A breaker that keeps tripping is a warning, not a nuisance. Call an electrician instead of resetting it over and over.

# Emergency contacts

For anything life-threatening, call 911 first. Poison Control is 1-800-222-1222 anywhere in the U.S.

| Who | Name or company | Phone | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| **UTILITIES** | | | |
| **Electric**<br>Outages and downed lines | | | |
| **Gas**<br>Leaks, 24 hours | | | |
| **Water and sewer** | | | |
| **Internet** | | | |
| **HELP WITH THE HOUSE** | | | |
| **Insurance claims** | | | |
| **Plumber** | | | |
| **Electrician** | | | |
| **Heating and cooling** | | | |
| **Roofer** | | | |
| **Water damage cleanup** | | | |
| **Handyman** | | | |
| **PEOPLE** | | | |
| **Neighbor** | | | |
| **Has a spare key** | | | |
| **Family contact** | | | |
| **Non-emergency police** | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |

# If something goes wrong

What to do first, before help arrives. Take photos before you clean up: your insurance company will ask for them.

### Gas smell

1. Don't flip switches, light anything or start a car in the garage.
2. Get everyone out. Leave the door open behind you.
3. Call the gas company or 911 from outside, away from the house.
4. Wait until they say it's safe to go back in.

### Burst pipe or big leak

1. Turn off the main water shutoff.
2. Turn off power to wet rooms at the panel, but only if you can reach it without standing in water.
3. Open a low faucet to drain the pipes.
4. Call a plumber, then your insurance company.

### Power outage

1. Check your breaker panel, and whether neighbors are out too.
2. Report it to the electric company.
3. Unplug computers and TVs so a surge doesn't hit them.
4. Keep the fridge closed. Food stays safe about 4 hours; a full freezer about 48.
5. Never run a generator indoors or in the garage.

### No heat in winter

1. Check the thermostat setting and its batteries.
2. Check the breaker and the furnace switch (it looks like a light switch near the furnace).
3. Change the filter. A clogged one can shut the furnace down.
4. Still nothing? Call for service, and let faucets drip if it's below freezing.

### Sewer or drain backup

1. Stop running water and flushing toilets.
2. Keep people and pets out of the water. It isn't safe to touch.
3. Call a plumber.
4. Call your insurance company. Many policies cover this only with a sewer backup add-on.

### Storm damage

1. Stay far away from downed power lines.
2. Take photos and video of the damage first.
3. Stop more damage if it's safe: tarp, towels, buckets. Keep the receipts.
4. Call your insurance company. Be wary of door-to-door contractors who want a big deposit.

# Appliance log

One box per appliance. The label is usually inside the door, on the back, or behind the bottom panel. Print as many as you need.

APPLIANCE | BRAND | INSTALLED OR BOUGHT

MODEL NUMBER | SERIAL NUMBER

WHERE BOUGHT | PRICE | WARRANTY ENDS | FILTER OR PART NUMBER

SERVICE AND NOTES

APPLIANCE | BRAND | INSTALLED OR BOUGHT

MODEL NUMBER | SERIAL NUMBER

WHERE BOUGHT | PRICE | WARRANTY ENDS | FILTER OR PART NUMBER

SERVICE AND NOTES

APPLIANCE | BRAND | INSTALLED OR BOUGHT

MODEL NUMBER | SERIAL NUMBER

WHERE BOUGHT | PRICE | WARRANTY ENDS | FILTER OR PART NUMBER

SERVICE AND NOTES

# How old is it?

Age is the best clue to how much life something has left. Here's how to find it from the label, even when no date is printed.

- [ ] **Look for a printed date first.** "MFG date," "DOM" (date of manufacture) or "Mfd," usually near the serial number.
- [ ] **No date? Find the serial number** and look up the brand below. Write what you find on the appliance page and the What's coming up page.

| Brand | How to read the serial number | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **Rheem, Ruud**<br>Water heaters, furnaces, AC | The first four digits are the month and year. | **Q0815…** = August 2015 |
| **A.O. Smith, State**<br>Water heaters | The first four digits are the year, then the week. | **1734…** = 2017, week 34 (late August) |
| **Carrier, Bryant, Payne**<br>Furnaces and AC | The first four digits are the week, then the year. | **2317…** = week 23 of 2017 (early June) |
| **Trane, American Standard**<br>Furnaces and AC, 2010 and newer | The first four digits are the year, then the week. | **1932…** = 2019, week 32 (early August) |
| **Goodman**<br>Furnaces and AC | The first four digits are the year, then the month. | **1606…** = June 2016 |
| **LG**<br>Appliances | The first digit is the last digit of the year. The next two are the month. | **905…** = May 2019 |
| **Frigidaire, Electrolux**<br>Appliances | Skip the first two letters. The next digit is the last digit of the year, then two digits for the week. | **BA723…** = 2017, week 23 (June) |
| **Bosch, Thermador**<br>Appliances | Look for "FD" on the label. Add 1920 to the first two digits for the year; the last two are the month. | **FD 9505** = May 2015 |

### GE

Appliances

The first letter is the month and the second letter is the year. Both use the same twelve letters. Example: `HR…` = May 2020.

| A | D | F | G | H | L | M | R | S | T | V | Z |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Jan<br>2013 · 25 | Feb<br>2014 · 26 | Mar<br>2015 | Apr<br>2016 | May<br>2017 | Jun<br>2018 | Jul<br>2019 | Aug<br>2020 | Sep<br>2021 | Oct<br>2022 | Nov<br>2023 | Dec<br>2024 |

**A one-digit year repeats every 10 years** (GE letters every 12), so pick the one that fits the house. Not every model follows these patterns. If the answer looks wrong, call the maker with the serial number.

**Short on time?** The Tallihaus app reads the label from a photo and works out the age for you.

# Heating and cooling

The filter size is printed on the edge of the old filter. Most filters need changing every 1–3 months.

### Furnace or air handler

BRAND

YEAR INSTALLED

MODEL NUMBER

SERIAL NUMBER

FILTER SIZE

CHANGE EVERY

INSTALLED BY

### Air conditioner or heat pump

BRAND

YEAR INSTALLED

MODEL NUMBER

SERIAL NUMBER

SIZE (TONS)

WARRANTY ENDS

INSTALLED BY

THERMOSTAT

HUMIDIFIER PAD OR FILTER

USUAL SERVICE COMPANY

## Service record

| Date | What was done | Who | Cost |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
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# Water heater and plumbing

Most tank water heaters last 8–12 years. Flushing one every year clears out the sediment that wears it down.

## Water heater

BRAND

YEAR INSTALLED

MODEL NUMBER

SERIAL NUMBER

SIZE (GALLONS)

WARRANTY ENDS

LAST FLUSHED

ANODE ROD CHECKED

## Other plumbing

SUMP PUMP AGE

BATTERY BACKUP?

WATER SOFTENER

SALT TYPE

WATER FILTER CARTRIDGE

CHANGE EVERY

SEPTIC LAST PUMPED

SEPTIC COMPANY

## Service record

| Date | What was done | Who | Cost |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
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# Roof, outside and windows

The big, expensive parts. Knowing their ages helps you plan before they need replacing.

| Part | Year | Material or brand | Installed by | Warranty until |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Roof**<br>Lasts about 20–25 years | | | | |
| **Gutters and guards** | | | | |
| **Siding** | | | | |
| **Windows** | | | | |
| **Front door** | | | | |
| **Other outside doors** | | | | |
| **Garage door** | | | | |
| **Garage door opener** | | | | |
| **Deck or patio** | | | | |
| **Driveway** | | | | |
| **Fence** | | | | |
| **Sprinklers** | | | | |
| **Chimney** | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |

## Notes

Window sizes, shingle color, gate codes

# Warranty tracker

Every warranty on one page, so nothing runs out without you noticing.

## Home warranty plan

If you have one

COMPANY

PHONE

CONTRACT (LAST 4)

RENEWS ON

SERVICE FEE

WHAT IT DOESN'T COVER

| Item | Company | What it covers | Ends | Paperwork kept |
|---|---|---|---|---|
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# Sizes and spare parts

The numbers you need at the hardware store. Take a photo of the old one before you go.

| Item | Size or part number | Where to buy | Keep on hand |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Furnace filter**<br>Printed on the edge | | | |
| **Humidifier pad** | | | |
| **Fridge water filter** | | | |
| **Range hood filter** | | | |
| **Whole-house water filter** | | | |
| **Air purifier filter** | | | |
| **Smoke alarm batteries** | | | |
| **CO alarm batteries** | | | |
| **Thermostat batteries** | | | |
| **Garage remote batteries** | | | |
| **Light bulbs, main rooms** | | | |
| **Outdoor light bulbs** | | | |
| **Specialty bulbs**<br>Ceiling fan, oven, fridge | | | |
| **Toilet flapper**<br>Brand and size | | | |
| **Faucet cartridges** | | | |
| **Window screen sizes** | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |

## Where the meters are

ELECTRIC METER

GAS METER

WATER METER

# What's coming up

The big replacements, planned ahead. Fill in the year each one went in to see when it's likely due and what to set aside.

| Item | Life (years) | Typical cost | Year installed | Likely due | Save per month |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Roof (asphalt shingles) | 20–25 | $10,000–15,000 | | | |
| Furnace | 15–20 | $4,000–7,000 | | | |
| Air conditioner or heat pump | 12–15 | $5,000–9,000 | | | |
| Water heater (tank) | 8–12 | $1,500–2,500 | | | |
| Refrigerator | 10–15 | $1,200–2,500 | | | |
| Range or oven | 13–15 | $900–1,800 | | | |
| Dishwasher | 9–12 | $700–1,200 | | | |
| Washing machine | 10–12 | $800–1,300 | | | |
| Dryer | 10–13 | $700–1,200 | | | |
| Microwave | 8–10 | $300–600 | | | |
| Garbage disposal | 8–12 | $250–400 | | | |
| Sump pump | 7–10 | $500–800 | | | |
| Garage door opener | 10–15 | $400–700 | | | |
| | | | | | |

**Example:** your water heater went in in 2017. They usually last 8–12 years, so plan for one around 2027. If that's 12 months away and a new one costs about $1,800, set aside $150 a month.

## The next five years

What's likely due, and roughly what it costs

| Year | What's likely due | Estimate |
|---|---|---|
| | | |
| | | |
| | | |
| | | |
| | | |

Rough 2026 U.S. prices with basic installation. Get local quotes when it's time.

# Every month

Ten minutes, once a month. Check a box as you go.

| Task | Jan | Feb | Mar | Apr | May | Jun | Jul | Aug | Sep | Oct | Nov | Dec |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Test smoke and CO alarms | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Check the furnace or AC filter | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Look under sinks for leaks | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Run water in sinks and showers you rarely use | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Clean the garbage disposal | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Clean the range hood filter | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Check the fire extinguisher gauge | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Pour a bucket of water in the sump pit to test the pump | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Walk around outside and look for anything new | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |

**Why run water in unused drains?** Each drain has a water trap that blocks sewer gas. If it dries out, you'll smell it.

# Spring and summer

Write the date when it's done, so next year you'll know when you last did it.

## Spring

- [ ] **Clean gutters and downspouts** — DATE _____
  Make sure downspouts send water several feet from the house.
- [ ] **Have the AC serviced** — DATE _____
  Before the first hot week, when service companies get busy.
- [ ] **Look over the roof from the ground** — DATE _____
  Missing or curling shingles after winter. Binoculars help.
- [ ] **Turn on outdoor faucets and check for leaks** — DATE _____
  A pipe that froze over winter often leaks inside the wall.
- [ ] **Check caulk and paint outside** — DATE _____
  Around windows, doors and trim, where water gets in.
- [ ] **Check that the ground slopes away from the house** — DATE _____
  Fill low spots near the foundation with soil.
- [ ] **Clean window screens and tracks** — DATE _____
- [ ] **Get the mower ready** — DATE _____
  Sharpen the blade, change the oil.

## Summer

- [ ] **Clean the dryer vent duct** — DATE _____
  Lint buildup is a leading cause of house fires.
- [ ] **Check the deck and railings** — DATE _____
  If water soaks in instead of beading up, it's time to seal it.
- [ ] **Trim plants away from the house and AC unit** — DATE _____
  Leave about two feet of space.
- [ ] **Look for pests** — DATE _____
  Mud tubes on the foundation can mean termites. Check for wasp nests.
- [ ] **Test the garage door's safety reverse** — DATE _____
  It should back up when something blocks it.
- [ ] **Clean the fridge coils** — DATE _____
  Under or behind the fridge. Dusty coils make it work harder.
- [ ] **Check the attic** — DATE _____
  Stains on the wood, damp insulation, or signs of animals.

# Fall and winter

Most of fall is getting ready for the cold. Most of winter is watching for problems.

## Fall

- [ ] **Have the furnace serviced** — DATE
  Before the first cold night.
- [ ] **Clean gutters after the leaves fall** — DATE
- [ ] **Shut off and drain outdoor faucets** — DATE
  Unhook hoses so the pipes don't freeze and burst.
- [ ] **Check weatherstripping and door sweeps** — DATE
  If you can see daylight around a door, heat is getting out.
- [ ] **Have the chimney inspected** — DATE
  Once a year if you use the fireplace.
- [ ] **Flush the water heater** — DATE
- [ ] **Change smoke and CO alarm batteries** — DATE
  An easy one to do when the clocks change.
- [ ] **Blow out the sprinkler lines** — DATE
- [ ] **Switch ceiling fans to clockwise** — DATE
  Pushes warm air back down from the ceiling.

## Winter

- [ ] **Watch for ice dams** — DATE
  Big icicles along the roof edge can mean water is backing up under shingles.
- [ ] **Keep outside vents clear of snow** — DATE
  Furnace and water heater vents need air to run safely.
- [ ] **Protect pipes in a deep freeze** — DATE
  Let faucets on outside walls drip and open the cabinet doors under sinks.
- [ ] **Keep the heat at 55°F or higher when you travel** — DATE
- [ ] **Check the basement and attic for leaks** — DATE
- [ ] **Get quotes for spring projects** — DATE
  Contractors have more time in winter, and spring fills up fast.

# The year at a glance

A starting point. Shift things a month or two for your climate, and add your own on the lines.

### January

- [ ] Watch for ice dams
- [ ] Test the sump pump
- [ ] Clean the range hood filter

### February

- [ ] Gather tax papers, incl. form 1098
- [ ] Look for drafts
- [ ] Book spring services

### March

- [ ] Look for basement water
- [ ] Check the roof after winter
- [ ] Test smoke and CO alarms

### April

- [ ] Have the AC serviced
- [ ] Clean gutters
- [ ] Turn on outdoor faucets

### May

- [ ] Check caulk and paint outside
- [ ] Clean window screens
- [ ] Check the ground slope

### June

- [ ] Clean the dryer vent
- [ ] Check the deck
- [ ] Trim plants from the house

### July

- [ ] Clean the fridge coils
- [ ] Look for pests
- [ ] Test the garage door reverse

### August

- [ ] Check the attic
- [ ] Seal driveway cracks
- [ ] Plan fall projects

### September

- [ ] Have the furnace serviced
- [ ] Check weatherstripping
- [ ] Chimney inspection

### October

- [ ] Drain outdoor faucets
- [ ] Clean gutters after leaves
- [ ] Ceiling fans to clockwise

### November

- [ ] Change alarm batteries
- [ ] Flush the water heater
- [ ] Blow out sprinklers

### December

- [ ] Protect pipes in cold spots
- [ ] Total up the year's costs
- [ ] Update the home inventory

# Maintenance log

Everything that gets done to the house, big or small. Print more as you fill it.

| Date | What was done | Done by | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
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# Home improvement log

Upgrades and additions, like a new roof, a remodel or a deck. Not repairs.

**Why keep this: it can lower your taxes when you sell**

What you spend improving your home adds to what the IRS counts as your cost for the house. If your profit when you sell is more than the tax-free amount ($250,000, or $500,000 for married couples), these records lower the tax you owe. Keep the receipts with this page. Repairs and upkeep don't count.

| Date | Project | Contractor | Cost | Permit | Receipt |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | ☐ | ☐ |
| | | | | ☐ | ☐ |
| | | | | ☐ | ☐ |
| | | | | ☐ | ☐ |
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| | | | | ☐ | ☐ |

Not tax advice. Ask a tax professional about your situation.

# Contractors

The people who've worked on your house, and whether you'd call them again.

TRADE | COMPANY

PERSON | PHONE

LAST JOB AND DATE | HIRE AGAIN? ☐ Yes ☐ Maybe ☐ No

TRADE | COMPANY

PERSON | PHONE

LAST JOB AND DATE | HIRE AGAIN? ☐ Yes ☐ Maybe ☐ No

TRADE | COMPANY

PERSON | PHONE

LAST JOB AND DATE | HIRE AGAIN? ☐ Yes ☐ Maybe ☐ No

TRADE | COMPANY

PERSON | PHONE

LAST JOB AND DATE | HIRE AGAIN? ☐ Yes ☐ Maybe ☐ No

TRADE | COMPANY

PERSON | PHONE

LAST JOB AND DATE | HIRE AGAIN? ☐ Yes ☐ Maybe ☐ No

TRADE | COMPANY

PERSON | PHONE

LAST JOB AND DATE | HIRE AGAIN? ☐ Yes ☐ Maybe ☐ No

TRADE | COMPANY

PERSON | PHONE

LAST JOB AND DATE | HIRE AGAIN? ☐ Yes ☐ Maybe ☐ No

TRADE | COMPANY

PERSON | PHONE

LAST JOB AND DATE | HIRE AGAIN? ☐ Yes ☐ Maybe ☐ No

# Comparing quotes

For bigger jobs, get at least three. The lowest price isn't always the best deal.

PROJECT

DATE

| | Quote 1 | Quote 2 | Quote 3 |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Company** | | | |
| **Contact and phone** | | | |
| **THE WORK** | | | |
| **Price** | | | |
| **What's included** | | | |
| **What's not included** | | | |
| **Materials or brand** | | | |
| **Start date and length** | | | |
| **Cleanup and haul-away** | | | |
| **PEACE OF MIND** | | | |
| **Licensed and insured**<br>Ask for proof | | | |
| **Warranty on the work** | | | |
| **Permit included** | | | |
| **Deposit asked** | | | |
| **Reviews or references** | | | |
| **Gut feeling**<br>1 to 5 | | | |

**Red flags**

Wants most of the money up front, takes cash only, won't put the price in writing, or pressures you to decide today.

# Project planner

PROJECT

START

FINISH

WHY WE'RE DOING IT

BUDGET

ACTUAL COST

## To do

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

## Questions to ask

| Materials or item | Where to buy | Qty | Cost |
|---|---|---|---|
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BEFORE

AFTER

# Yearly home costs

What the house really costs to own. A common rule of thumb: set aside 1–2% of your home's value each year for upkeep.

YEAR

| Month | Mortgage | Utilities | Taxes and insurance (if not in escrow) | HOA | Repairs and upkeep | Improve-ments | Total |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Jan | | | | | | | |
| Feb | | | | | | | |
| Mar | | | | | | | |
| Apr | | | | | | | |
| May | | | | | | | |
| Jun | | | | | | | |
| Jul | | | | | | | |
| Aug | | | | | | | |
| Sep | | | | | | | |
| Oct | | | | | | | |
| Nov | | | | | | | |
| Dec | | | | | | | |
| TOTAL | | | | | | | |

## Looking back at the year

BIGGEST SURPRISE COST

NEXT YEAR WE SHOULD BUDGET FOR

# Utilities and accounts

Every regular bill for the house. Last four digits only.

| Service | Company | Account | Phone or website | Usual cost | Due | Autopay |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Electric | | | | | | ☐ |
| Gas | | | | | | ☐ |
| Water | | | | | | ☐ |
| Sewer | | | | | | ☐ |
| Trash and recycling | | | | | | ☐ |
| Internet | | | | | | ☐ |
| Security system | | | | | | ☐ |
| Lawn care | | | | | | ☐ |
| Pest control | | | | | | ☐ |
| Home warranty | | | | | | ☐ |
| | | | | | | ☐ |
| | | | | | | ☐ |
| | | | | | | ☐ |

## Pickup days

TRASH

RECYCLING

YARD WASTE OR BULK ITEMS

## Wi-Fi and devices

Network name only. Keep passwords in a password manager.

WI-FI NETWORK

ROUTER LOCATION

GARAGE CODE HOLDER

# Home inventory

For insurance claims after a fire, theft or storm. One page per room. The fastest way to start: walk each room recording a video, opening closets and drawers, and save it somewhere online.

ROOM

DATE

| Item | Brand and model | Serial number | Bought | Price | Receipt | Photo |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | ☐ | ☐ |
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# Where important papers are

Keep originals in a fireproof box or safe deposit box, and a scanned copy somewhere online.

| Document | Where it's kept | Scanned |
|---|---|---|
| Deed | | ☐ |
| Closing Disclosure or settlement statement | | ☐ |
| Mortgage note | | ☐ |
| Title insurance policy | | ☐ |
| Survey or plot plan | | ☐ |
| Home inspection report | | ☐ |
| Seller's disclosure | | ☐ |
| Homeowners insurance policy | | ☐ |
| Flood insurance policy | | ☐ |
| Home warranty contract | | ☐ |
| Property tax bills | | ☐ |
| Permits and plans | | ☐ |
| Appliance manuals and warranties | | ☐ |
| Improvement receipts | | ☐ |
| HOA rules and documents | | ☐ |
| Will or trust | | ☐ |
| | | ☐ |
| | | ☐ |

# Notes

**Rather keep this on your phone?**
The free Tallihaus app keeps your appliances, upkeep checklist and reminders, bills and mortgage in one place. It reads appliance labels and bills with your camera, so there's less to type.

Scan to get the free app